

Usability Study | File a Petition

Remote
November 2019

Study Information

In this study, Flexion UX Designers performed a usability study with potential petitioners to test the petitioner dashboard and file a petition flow.

Participants

- 15 total participants
 - 8 participants in age range 18-39
 - 3 participants in age range 40-65
 - 4 participants in age range 65 +
 - 5 on EST timezone; 10 in CST timezone

Sessions

- All sessions held remotely via Zoom using laptop or desktop computers

Limitations



Participants were provided a completed STIN and Petition form PDF and given a predefined scenario to use when completing the tasks. Findings related to completing the written petition and creating the actual PDF documents are based on participant speculation

Key Findings

- 😊 Form wizard is easy to use - All participants were able to complete the given task*
- 😞 Petitioners need better instructions about each of the required forms, what they are for, how to complete them, and where they will be used during the submission process
- 😞 Participants want real-life examples/ how-to videos for which forms to fill out, how to redact, how to merge pdfs
- 😞 Participants had questions about small and regular case procedures, and want more guidance around their eligibility and why choose a regular case over a small case
- 😞 Participants understood how to make changes to their information before submitting, but would benefit from a more direct edit functionality
- 😞 Participants want more direct instruction regarding the filing fee, and expect that the fee will be paid/waived as part of the submission process

Dashboard / Landing Page

“Language is easy to read and understand, not all that legal/government mumbo jumbo”

Findings

- Design and layout was clean and not intimidating
- Easy to locate the call-to-action and begin the petition process
- Most participants expressed that they would read the Petition Filing Guide before beginning the process
- Participants are able to navigate through the Petitioner Tools, but a indicator that these are external links would be helpful
- Filing fee information is obvious, but participants expect to be reminded of this later in the process and provided more details on payment and waiver options

Recommendations

- Consider adding simplified information on the petition process (infographics, etc.)
- Include filing fee payment options and when to pay information upfront
- Add external link icon for all petitioner tools

Instructions / Before You Begin

“It’s a lot to read”

“If you’re not a tax person or attorney, it’s not really English...”

Findings (General)

- Participants were not overwhelmed by the instructional page, but did express concern over the density of the information
- Participants generally felt the information was laid out nicely, found the iconography helpful
- Some participants have trouble understanding the some of the language used in the instructions
- One participant noted the timeliness information regarding the IRS Notice

Findings (Required Forms)

- Most participants expressed some level of confusion around the required forms, and would prefer a simplified way to identify what forms they need and why (most read the headings but not the text descriptions)
- It is not 100% clear that users need to download and complete each of the required forms
- Form names, including acronyms, were not familiar to participants, and caused confusion
- Participant(s) would prefer real-life examples for completing forms, redacting information, and merging PDFs
- Participant (1) expected alternative methods to combine documents if user does not have Adobe Acrobat Professional

Instructions / Before You Begin

Recommendations

- Overhaul the instructions completely and make them, available both on the public site and for authenticated users
- Break the form instructions down into bite-sized chunks to make it clear which forms need to be completed, what they are for, and when they will be used
- Spell out all acronyms in their first use
- Use plain language to rewrite all headers and descriptions
- Add visual examples of IRS Notices, STIN, and Petition forms, how to redact information from documents
- Add alternative instructions for merging PDFs for users without Adobe Pro

File Uploads (STIN and Petition)

“I already uploaded a document”

Findings (General)

- Participants could easily understand upload functionality
- Participants understood and liked the visual feedback (green check) for uploaded files, may be beneficial to have a more prominent success feedback
- Participant (1) could not upload a document due to browser incompatibility

Findings (STIN)

- Participants had trouble identifying the STIN acronym with the full form name
- Some participants did not understand what the STIN was and how it differed from the petition form

Findings (Petition)

- Participants noticed the warning message, but some assumed it applied to all documents (including the STIN)
- Participant (1) missed the upload field completely and thought they had already uploaded the required documents in the previous step
- Participant expect a reference or link to the petition form, USTC Form 2

File Uploads (STIN and Petition)

Recommendations

- Clearly define the file upload fields by user-friendly form names
- Inform the user upfront and more clearly how many PDF documents they will need to upload
- Include reference links to the corresponding forms co-located with upload field
- Clarify the redaction warning message to ensure that users understand that it does not apply to the STIN

Case Type

Findings

- Participants were easily able to select from the IRS Notice radio options
- All participants were able to select the appropriate notice type from the dropdown

Recommendations

- Provide examples of IRS notices to initial instructions page (low priority)

Party Type / Contact Information

Findings

- All participants were easily able to select the appropriate party type using the radio selections
- Participants expect option to copy address to spouse's contact information
- Some participants did not see the "All Fields Required" message, and expect to be informed which fields are required at the field level
- Participant (1) was confused about field label language for the "In Care Of" field
- Participant (1) expected formatting guidance for phone number field
- Participant (1) did not notice the Country select field during data entry
- Participant (1) did not understand the ODS form requirement (knows there are 3 forms but cannot identify which goes where)

Recommendations

- Add "copy" address functionality for spouse information
- Update "All Fields Required" to be more visible throughout the form
- Consider redesign / relocation of the ODS form fields for businesses to immediately follow the party type selector
- Change language on "In Care Of" fields to exclude "(Your Name)"

Case Procedure

“Not clear to me at all what this means”

“What’s in my own interest”

Findings

- Most participants were able to locate the helper accordion for Regular vs. Small case; one participant missed this and thought it should be more obvious
- Some participants were unclear on what they were being presented, what the case procedure means, and how selecting one over another will impact their case
- Participants expected more details on eligibility and benefits of a Regular Case procedure
- Participant (1) would prefer the system to suggest a case procedure based on the user’s case information

Recommendations

- Define what a “case procedure” is and what it will mean to the user in plain language
- Add logic to provide eligibility information to users based on their specific case
- Redesign the helper text to include parallel information between small case and regular case benefits

Trial Location

Findings

- Participants were easily able to select a trial location from the provided dropdown
- Some participants expected the closest location to be provided to them based on their address
- Participant (1) misunderstood the helper text initially, thought the excluded states were actually the available states
- Participant (1) found the long list of trial locations in dropdown difficult to parse, could be visually differentiated better

Recommendations

- Consider adding suggested trial locations based on petitioner address

Review Screen

Findings

- All participants noticed and read the warning message; liked styling
- Participants understood and liked the PDF preview available from the review screen
- Participants understand to edit they would “back” through the wizard and this is expected; an option to edit inline or directly link to a page would be beneficial
- Participant (1) did not understand what the service email means; terminology is unfamiliar
- All participants read the reminders and generally found them helpful
- Some participants were confused by reminders regarding evidence and combining petition and IRS notice - second-guessing what should be included in their PDF uploads
- Participant (1) did not understand what “timely” meant in reminders

Recommendations

- Add more direct edit functionality
- Define service email more clearly, and add information about what this email will be used for throughout the case
- Revise reminder text for clarification around PDF inclusions/exclusions; consider co-locating with PDF previews

Confirmation / Case Detail

“Will I ever see this again?”

Findings

- All participants were able to locate their new case, but some found the terminology (docket number) unfamiliar
- Participants easily navigated to Case Detail screen; information presented was clear
- Participants expect paying the filing fee to be part of the submission process; or to see some other notification/reminder that the petition is pending until the fee is received
- Participants expect an email notification that the petition was successfully submitted
- Participants expect more information regarding “next steps”, and how they will receive information in the future (by either logging in to the app or via email notifications)

Recommendations

- Define court terminology more clearly (especially “docket”)
- Add dynamic text to success message to say “You’ve been assigned docket # XXX”
- Consider including option to pay filing fee as part of the online petition process, or provide immediate payment options after submission
- Add “what to expect” information after petition is submitted, including what happens next in the process, how petitioner will be notified of updates, etc.)
- Create null state for Case Detail > Case Information tab for external parties

Summary | Recommendations

Recommendations Summary

Dashboard / Landing Page

- ! Consider adding simplified information on the petition process (infographics, etc.)
 - Include filing fee payment options and when to pay information upfront
 - Add external link icon for all petitioner tools

Instructions

- ! Create simplified instructional materials, available on the public site
- ! Break the form instructions down into bite-sized chunks to make it clear which forms need to be completed, what they are for, and when they will be used
- ! Spell out all acronyms in their first use
- ! Use plain language to rewrite all headers and descriptions
 - Add visual examples of IRS Notices, STIN, and Petition forms, how to redact information from documents
- ! Add alternative instructions for merging PDFs for users without Adobe Pro

Recommendations Summary

File Uploads

- ! Clearly define the file upload fields by user-friendly form names
- ! Inform the user upfront of how many PDF documents they will need to upload
- ! Include reference links to the corresponding forms co-located with upload field
- ! Clarify the redaction warning message to ensure that users understand that it does not apply to the STIN

Case Type

- Provide examples of IRS notices to initial instructions page; reference here

Party Type / Contact Information

- Add “copy” address functionality for spouse information
- Update “All Fields Required” to be more visible throughout the form
- Consider redesign / relocation of the ODS form fields for businesses to immediately follow the party type selector
- Change language on “In Care Of” fields to exclude “(Your Name)”

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Case Procedure

- ! Define what a “case procedure” is and what it will mean to the user in plain language
 - Add logic to provide eligibility information to users based on their specific case
- ! Redesign the helper text to include parallel information between small case and regular case benefits

Trial Location

- Consider adding suggested trial locations based on petitioner address (Post-MVP)

Review Screen

- ! Add more direct edit functionality
 - Define service email more clearly, and add information about what this email will be used for throughout the case
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Recommendations Summary

Confirmation / Case Detail

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Questions | Come on, let us have 'em!

Appendix

Dashboard / Landing Page (Raw Notes)

General

- “Very clean looking”
- Easy to identify the “File a Petition as the call-to-action
- Welcoming by name - must have been here before
- Thinks because it says My Cases they she already has a case in the system
- Assumption would be that she needs to file a petition to dispute the notice
- What you expect is clear
- “Language is easy to read and understand, “not all that legal/government mumbo jumbo”

Filing Fee

- Worried about how he will pay the fee, etc, but assumes that will be explained later on

Petitioner Tools

- Would open each link in separate tab - review those and come back to site
- Easily finds file a petition - says he understands what to do “OK”
- Says it clear that he would have to download the forms and fill them out
- Reluctant to click on link- Afraid they’d take her away and she wouldn’t be able to get back
 - Would like links to open in new window have icon available to display that
- Would read over the petition filing guide a few times to make sure she’s prepared
- Would go to Petition Filing Guide first

Dashboard/ Landing Page - Raw Notes

- Looking for prompts on the dashboard, where to go to do something
- Eyes are drawn to file a petition button
- Comments about not liking that there's a fee - would want to see about the waiver on the dashboard and confused about when it would be paid - after the case is done??

Instructions / Tips Page (Raw Notes)

- Reads all instructions “it’s a lot to read”
- Daunting steps for things to know to prep before filing
- Scrolls up and down
- Icons are big and bold which makes them have more warning - better really pay attention
- Would at least read the headlines - if didn’t understand then would read the explanation - otherwise would just skim headers
- Instructions page - user friendly but a lot of info
- Would read it - for US gov so would read it all
- Unsure if it would be helpful to read before starting the process
- Like that it says DO NOT in bold
- Concerned about fee - wonders if she pays by mail if she owes it
- File button is prominent - first sees search, then sidebar, then well content
- Tips page is laid out nicely, like icons, more engaging than plain text
- Need to upload notice - not info about how to scan it in but she assumes that what she has to do
- Have to do more printing and fill out things - let me know that I can fill it out online and not print/rescan

Authorized Filer

- Authorized- understands he authorized to file for himself - based on what he’s reading, brings up more questions - would assume he’s authorized to file for both him and his wife
- Would give pause - then would wonder if she needs an attorney - would assume she’s authorized if filing for herself

Instructions / Tips Page (Raw Notes)

Notice Info / Timeliness

- IRS Notices - reviews both PDFs provided - “I guess we have the notices, right”
- Understands the notice info - “that’s fine”
- Notices the time cutoff - Expects the timeliness info to be elsewhere
- Go find your notice and put that with petition - that’s clear

Forms

- Make clear that USTC is acronym, didn’t connect that right away
- Would open each link in new tab - expects links that open in new tab to have icon
- “This is dense” - re: the Petition form
- Understands the use of the term “Petition” but it’s not immediately clear
- Doesn’t think language makes sense - “if you’re not a tax person or attorney - it’s not really english”
- Form names are confusing - abbreviation of USTC should be spelled out
- Would like more real-life examples for the steps 2-5 in the instructions
- Would not be clear that he needs to fill out all of those forms - STIN, Petition, etc.
- Would prefer it to be simple - “there are 3 forms” -
- Numbering would help 1, 2, 3
- Clear explanation of the STIN form
- The other 2 forms isn’t as clear - doesn’t tell you what the form is for
- Doesn't understand that the ODS is only required for certain petitioner types
- Forms - clear that there are three forms
- At very least would need 2 form

Would like to see the document names stand out a little more, bold or italicize

Instructions / Tips Page (Raw Notes)

Redaction

- Some info #4 is repetitive
- Thinks if you don't know how to redact the information - then you shouldn't be doing it yourself - understands the need
- Understands redaction
- Would read instructions- concerned if she doesn't have adobe acrobat - maybe have other option
- Clear not to submit any additional info
- I'd call someone to help me redact - don't know how to do that

Merging PDFs

- may not be easy for them to do (merging files into PDF)
- Notices the link to the directions and instructions seems sufficient
- Understands how to redact in Adobe - otherwise not sure how she would combine the PDF
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File Uploads (STIN) - Raw Notes

STIN

- Understand easily which document is the STIN - of the PDFs provided
- Understand which document provided was the petition (now)
- Pretty straightforward

- Has no idea what the STIN is or where that's from
- Able to upload and understand how to continue

- Abbreviation not being on the page is confusing
- File is correct- displaying the name and green check is confirmation that field is complete

- Isn't clear what this is
- He thought it was either the petition (dispute) or what he received from the IRS

- Checkmark means she did the right thing
- Likes the option to change the document

File Uploads (Petition) - Raw Notes

Petition

- Sees warning - looks at PDF to make sure no personal info is there
- Assumes warning on petition page applies to all docs
- Misses the Petition upload - Not clear that the Petition upload is a different document - "I just uploaded a document"
- Thinks labelling forms 1, 2, 3 would be easier - the proper name of the form doesn't help him when he's not familiar with them
- Would expect the form name to be here - USTC Form 2 or other options
- Not looking for a link but just a reminder
- Maybe link to sample would be helpful
- No issues selecting type of notice
- Likes flag in the warning message- easy to catch eye and understand
- On uploads, wants to see "info has been uploaded" or more prominent indicator that upload is ok and she can move on
- Could use help for IRS notice - pic or header so I know if I got one

Party Type / Contact Information - Raw Notes

Selecting Party Type

- No issue selecting radios
- Would expect if someone didn't see their selection then they'd choose other

Contact Info

- Would be nice to have address copy to spouse
 - In case (your name) - doesn't understand the field label
 - Thinks "For" would be a more clear label
- Glazed over the "All fields required" - would expect to see a label for "Required" as well as "optional"
- Showed her the "all fields required"
 - Totally missed it
 - Maybe make required in red to draw eye or put it next to "tell us about yourself"
- Phone number - questions what the phone format should be
- 1 tester missed the country drop down completely, look for standard of where placed in other forms?
- "File for..." little confused about if that's me or the my business cause it's MY business
- Very easy to fill out address - let's you tab
- Nice to have "copy address of spouse"
- Used to * indicating required - different than I'm used to
 - But no trouble filling out req fields

Ownership Disclosure Statement

ODS - not clear what form upload we're dealing with

- Knows there were 3 forms but they aren't identified easily in the wizard

Case Procedure

Regular vs. Small Case

- “Not clear to me at all what this means”
- Which case should i choose- clean design
- Would want to map the notice type to the case type - Collections; be nice if there was a reference number to the petition so he doesn’t have to choose
- Seems a little smoother, less friction to go through process
- Would be useful to know if there’s a benefit of filing as a regular case, notices the “no Appeals process”
- “How much more trouble is this” (if he chooses regular case)
- Upfront he didn’t really understand what the choice he was making was
 - What’s in his own interest - wasn’t clear he was making a decision to affect the cases
- Doesn’t see explanation or accordion helper on screen
- Understands the differences between the case procedures but doesn’t seem confident around what option to select
- Wants the helper info to be more in your face - e”everyone should read this before selecting”
- Knows it’s not eligible for small case due to the amount
- Doesn’t even look at helper text
- Was wondering which she should choose - easily sees the helper text
- Likes the small case benefits
- Would expect more info regarding regular case - eligibility and benefits
- “S” under small case table not clear
- Confused about what case size to pick - help should stand out more
- “I’m a small case cause I qualify for a small case” - missed the 4 boxes at the bottom
- Help feature - lot of good info on r/s case
- Unsure how to click to close the expandable
- “Sounds like I need to choose small case”
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Trial Location- Raw Notes

Trial Location Selector

- No problem selecting trial location
- Would expect it to give you closest location based on entered address
- Sees trial locations link on dashboard after submitting the petition - could be useful to draw attention to this
- “Oh that’s rough, you may have to go to another state for trial”
- Skims trial location options - doesn’t see “unavailable” at first
- Long list of trial locations
- The states kind of run together a bit- the gray and bold doesn’t help too much

Review Screen- Raw Notes

PDF Preview

- Clicks on petition - oh this is what i uploaded
- Straightforward - confirmation that what he uploaded was received
- Likes how the PDF viewer pops up and allow you to rview quickly

Editing

- If had to edit, understands he's click back button
 - Would be nice to be able to edit right there- not confused by having to go back
- Editing- back button would be fine - Doesn't expect any edit button here
- Would like to make changes on the review page, would make it easier and take less time then stepping back through wizard
 - Stepping back people might forget info
- Likes the yellow alert flag, "people are use to red and will look past it, the yellow is different and good.
- "It says I can't change the petition so how would I go back?"
- Does finally see back button

Service Email

- Service email - would be wondering if she'll get an email that it was submitted
 - Will i get a copy of this document?
 - What does service email mean? Term is confusing to layperson

Reminders

- Reads redaction warning - understands
- Reads through all info on review page
- Good to have the reminders
- Reminders - Confused by single PDF - am i missing a file is my question?
- #3 - reinforce that you are only submitting the petition and STIN
- Reminders section is smooshed and the submit button is kind of lost
 - Need more space above Submit button
- Get's error uploading - no way to "close" error modal without losing everythin

Review Screen - Raw Notes

- Confused about redacting on review page cause it doesn't mention STIN exception - also confused about when that was supposed to happen
- Review page - good to know I can't edit
- Not scary language on reminders
- Good progress bar, confirmation is good

Confirmation - Raw Notes

My Cases

- Easily finds new case on dashboard and is able to access it
- Filing fee- was there a callout for the fee earlier?
- Assumes docket record is legal term - would like a definition or something
- Doesn't know how he would be notified about the case - not clear to him on the Case Detail page - what's next
- Now sees case - opens to look at to make sure it's correct
- My cases not obvious as dashboard
- Does not understand what docket number is. In success box would be good
- Thought the success message was confusing and suggested adding "you've been given a docket #"

Filing Fee

- Filing fee- was there a callout for the fee earlier?
- Would expect to have to pay before could even submit
 - Sees action required is there, but isn't in the docket record itself - would expect the Petition to have some sort of "flag" showing that filing fee is still needed
- Would expect the filing fee to be part of the submission process - would forget
 - Or would want some reminder that the filing fee is needed

Next Steps/ Expected

- Opens file to check petition
- Sees filing fee info
- Would look at Printable Docket Record - likes that it opens in new window
- Would add that you can log in any time to view you case
- Wants to know "will i ever see this again"
- Would go to email to see if she got receipt notification
- Would like an email of confirmation of file and reminder of fee due
- How do I know what comes next? Will I be notified of next steps and once things are happening on the case?
-

Confirmation - Raw Notes

- “It’s overall pretty easy and reminds me of other systems”
- “Wording is simple to me:
- On dashboard, would look at tools on sidebar and be hesitant cause they are asking for money - explain why you pay the fee
- On success message on dashboard, thought “dismiss” would dismiss the whole petition filing - suggested just an X in corner
- “I managed to get through without too many mistakes. Can’t say that about other government forms”
- Doesn’t tell me where to send mon